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Everything you need to know about moving to Australia.

Medicare, Ahpra registration, visas, tax and superannuation work the same way wherever you land; pay, schools and the feel of daily life change from state to state. This is the layer underneath the city guides: the systems, the money, the paperwork and the rhythm of the year, written for healthcare professionals and their families.

8

states and territories,
each with its own
character

1

national registration
scheme for most health
professions

~1 in 3

people born overseas

12%

employer
superannuation, paid on
top of your salary

IN THIS GUIDE

01 Fourteen city guides

02 Why clinicians choose Australia

03 A continent of states and territories

04 How the health system works

05 Getting registered to practise

06 The visa usually follows the job

07 How pay works in Australian healthcare

08 What it costs to live here

09 Sophie's insights

10 Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander
cultures

11 Bringing your culture and faith with you

12 Moving as a family

13 Choosing where in Australia to live

14 Useful contacts

15 Your Ethicare journey

Guides describe places, not employers. Hospitals are described rather than named, and salaries, visas and registration rules change, so we confirm the detail with you directly.

Where could you see yourself?

Every guide covers the same ground for one place: the work, the suburbs, the weather, the month's money and the weekends. Start with the one that caught your eye.



NEW SOUTH WALES

Sydney

Warrane



VICTORIA

Melbourne

Naarm



QUEENSLAND

Brisbane

Meanjin



AUSTRALIAN CAPITAL TERRITORY

Canberra

Ngunnawal Country



TASMANIA

Hobart

nipaluna



WESTERN AUSTRALIA

Perth

Boorloo



SOUTH AUSTRALIA

Adelaide

Tarntanya



NORTHERN TERRITORY

Darwin

Garramilla



QUEENSLAND

Gold Coast

Yugambah Country



NEW SOUTH WALES

Newcastle

Awabakal Country



VICTORIA

Geelong

Wadawurrung Country



QUEENSLAND

Bundaberg

Taribelang Bunda, Gooreng Gooreng, Gurang and Bailai Country



WESTERN AUSTRALIA

Mandurah

Bindjareb Noongar Country



WESTERN AUSTRALIA

Bunbury

Goomburrup

Why clinicians choose Australia

Few people move to Australia for the salary alone. They come for the sun, the space and the time, and for a large, modern health system with real room to grow.

The reasons healthcare professionals give us are remarkably consistent. Warm weather and a coastline woven into ordinary life, not just the holidays. A good place to raise children, with safe communities, strong schools and a childhood spent largely outside. And a career in a big public and private health system, with genuine choice over where and how you work.

Registration is national, so the same registration lets you work from a harbour city to a regional town and move between states later without starting your paperwork again. Many clinicians move once or twice as they find the pace and place that suits them.

Australia is also one of the most multicultural countries on earth. Most newcomers find a community that already feels familiar, and colleagues and neighbours who fold them in quickly.



Kings Park in Perth, a short walk from the city: the after-work stroll, not the holiday.

WHAT PEOPLE LOVE

Sun and the outdoors

The early swim, the weekend at the beach and long light evenings quickly become the parts of the week people protect most.

Room to grow

Teaching, research, private practice and regional roles with broad scope, all under one registration.

A flatter culture of care

First names, open communication and teams where your opinion is expected, not merely permitted.

WORTH PLANNING FOR

The distance from home

Flights back are long, so families who build regular trips and calls into the plan settle most happily.

Big-city housing

Sydney and Melbourne in particular reward careful planning; many other cities go much further.

The paperwork

Registration, visa and the role run alongside each other. It is very doable, and starting early is the secret.

“

The role is why you come. The sunshine, the space and the time are why you stay.



The tropical coast of Far North Queensland.

A continent of states and territories

Australia is roughly the size of mainland Europe, with most of its people living along the coast. Six states and two territories each run their own hospitals, schools and roads, so where you land shapes daily life more than you might expect.

The six states are New South Wales, Victoria, Queensland, Western Australia, South Australia and Tasmania; the two mainland territories are the Australian Capital Territory, home to Canberra, and the Northern Territory. Each capital is the hub of its state's health system, and most hold the state's major teaching and tertiary hospitals.

Distances are on a different scale. Sydney to Perth is a four- to five-hour flight, about the same as London to the eastern Mediterranean, so domestic flying is the normal way to cross the country. Within a state, a regional city may be a long drive or a short flight from the capital, and that distance is part of what makes regional practice so varied.

Before anyone else, this was, and always will be, Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander land. Every city in these guides sits on the Country of a particular people, and each city guide names its Traditional Custodians.



The Red Centre: Kata Tjuta, in the Northern Territory.



The southern coast: the Twelve Apostles on Victoria's Great Ocean Road.

6 + 2

six states and
two mainland
territories

4–5 hrs

to fly coast to
coast
Sydney to Perth

~85%

of people live
within 50km of
the coast

3

time zones on the
mainland
more when
daylight saving is
in force

Summer

DEC – FEB

Long, warm to hot days in the south; Christmas at the beach and the long school holidays. In the tropical north this is the wet season, with storms and lush green.

Autumn

MAR – MAY

Settled, golden weather across the south, and for many people the best time of year to be outdoors.

Winter

JUN – AUG

Mild and sunny in Brisbane, Perth and the north; crisp in Canberra, Melbourne and Hobart, with snow in the Alps and Tasmania's highlands. The dry season makes the Top End glorious.

Spring

SEP – NOV

Wildflowers in the west, jacarandas in bloom, and the whole country heading back outside.

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Several climates, one country

Tropical in the north, from Darwin to Cairns, with a wet and a dry season rather than four. Subtropical in Brisbane and along the northern New South Wales coast. Temperate in Sydney, Perth and Adelaide, with hot dry summers and mild winters. Cooler and properly four-season in Melbourne, Canberra and Hobart. Arid across the vast interior. Whatever you love about weather, there is a city that suits it.



The tropics: Cairns, in Far North Queensland.



Four true seasons: a Hobart garden in autumn.

How the health system works

Australia runs a universal public system, funded through taxation and a Medicare levy, alongside a large private sector. Most people use a mix of the two across their lives, and many clinicians work in both.

Medicare is the national scheme that covers free treatment as a public patient in a public hospital and subsidises GP visits, tests and many specialist services. Medicines are subsidised through the Pharmaceutical Benefits Scheme, which caps what most people pay at the pharmacy counter.

Public hospitals are run by the states and territories, through their own health departments and regional health services, with national funding underneath. That is why standards are broadly consistent wherever you live, and why your employer, pay and conditions are set by the state you work in rather than nationally.

Alongside sits one of the world's largest private health sectors: private hospitals, imaging and day-surgery centres, and specialist rooms, funded by insurance and patient fees. Private care offers choice of provider and often shorter waits for elective procedures, while the public system carries emergency, acute and complex care, and most of the teaching and training.

NATIONAL COVER

Medicare

Free public hospital care and rebates towards GP visits, tests and specialists. Citizens and permanent residents enrol, as do many visitors from reciprocal-agreement countries.

WHERE MOST OF OUR ROLES SIT

State public health services

Hospitals and community services run by each state and territory, with their own enterprise agreements, rosters and induction.

THE FRONT DOOR

General practice

Privately run and Medicare-funded. Some clinics bulk-bill (nothing to pay); others charge a gap fee, so ask when you book.

SUBSIDISED MEDICINES

The PBS

Keeps listed prescriptions affordable, with a lower cap for concession-card holders and a yearly safety net.

ALONGSIDE, NOT INSTEAD

The private sector

Private hospitals, imaging and specialist practices. A genuine career route in its own right, and many clinicians build a mix.



Team-based, relatively flat and collaborative: the culture most clinicians come to value.

Good to know for your family

- ✓ Your Medicare position depends on your visa and passport. The UK, Ireland, New Zealand and eight other countries have reciprocal agreements; others hold private cover, often as a visa condition.
- ✓ Adult dental, optical and most allied health sit largely outside Medicare, which is what extras insurance is for.
- ✓ Ambulance cover is arranged state by state. A quick check in your first week is all it takes.
- ✓ Register the family with a GP early, before anyone is unwell.
- ✓ In an emergency call 000. For advice when you are unsure, healthdirect is free, around the clock.



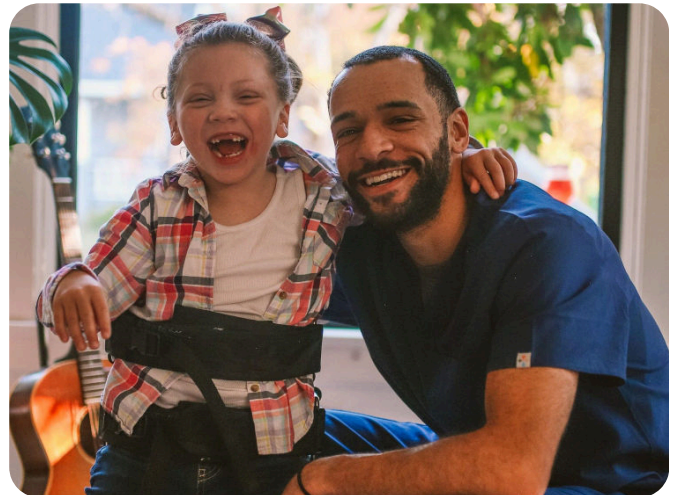
General practice is the front door for most everyday care.



Care that feels a touch less rushed is what many clinicians notice first.



Internationally trained nurses are part of every team.



Paediatric and rehabilitation work is a growing part of the system.



In theatre.



A newborn check



Everyday care for young families.

Getting registered to practise

Australia runs one national registration scheme. Once you are registered, it is recognised in every state and territory, so registration opens the whole country at once.

Most health professions are regulated through Ahpra, the Australian Health Practitioner Regulation Agency, working with a National Board for each profession. The boards set the standards; Ahpra runs the applications. A few professions, sonography among them, sit outside the scheme and are accredited by their own professional body instead.

Registration lets you practise; a visa lets you live and work here. They are separate, run by different organisations, and lining them up so neither holds the other up is most of the art. A migration skills assessment is a third, separate step that only some visa routes need.

For professions that operate radiation equipment, there is one more step: a state or territory radiation use licence, issued once you are registered. Employers arrange this all the time and usually help.

PROFESSION	REGISTRATION OR ACCREDITATION	THE SHAPE OF IT
Radiographers	Medical Radiation Practice Board (MRPBA), through Ahpra	Diagnostic radiographer division, with a comparable-regulator route for HCPC (UK) and CORU (Ireland) registrants.
Radiation therapists	Medical Radiation Practice Board (MRPBA), through Ahpra	Radiation therapist division, with HCPC and CORU recognition.
Nuclear medicine technologists	Medical Radiation Practice Board (MRPBA), through Ahpra	Individual assessment is usual; ANZSNM is the skills assessor for migration.
Sonographers	ASMIRT recognition, then ASAR accreditation	Not a protected title; ASAR accreditation is what links your work to Medicare.
Consultant radiologists	Medical Board of Australia, through Ahpra	Specialist registration, with a comparability assessment by RANZCR.
Nurses, doctors and other allied health	Their own National Board, through Ahpra	The same national scheme; each board publishes its own pathway for international applicants.

○ Work out your pathway

Your profession, where you trained and who you are registered with now decide the route.

○ Request the slow documents first

WEEKS

Certificates of good standing and verified qualifications move at other organisations' pace, so start them on day one.

○ Settle the English question

Evidence an exemption or book an approved test early. Scores are set per component.

○ Submit a complete application

MONTHS

A complete, well-evidenced pack is the single biggest lever on timing.

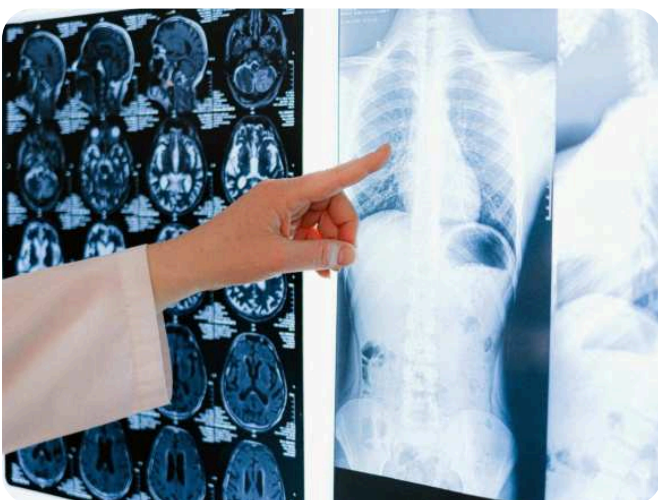
○ Registration, then any state licence

Recognised nationwide, renewed annually, with CPD going forward.

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Check at the source

Boards set their own requirements, fees and timelines, and these change. Confirm the current detail with Ahpra, your National Board or your accrediting body. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not a registration authority, and our support for you is free.



Medical imaging and radiation therapy are where our Australian service begins.



The Blue Mountains, west of Sydney.

The visa usually follows the job

Two routes cover most healthcare professionals: employer-sponsored, where an employer sponsors you for a specific role, or skilled migration, based on points and your occupation. For most of the clinicians we support, the role comes first and the visa follows.

On the employer-sponsored route you secure the role, your employer nominates you, and your visa application follows alongside or just after. You arrive with a job, an employer invested in your move and often relocation support, and a separate migration skills assessment generally is not needed just to register.

Skilled migration lets you apply in your own right, scored on age, English, qualifications and experience, without a specific employer first. It is where the skills assessment matters most, and where state nomination and regional pathways can add points and open doors.

Starting on one route rarely closes the other. Plenty of people arrive on an employer-sponsored visa and move to permanent residence later, through their employer or independently.

THE USUAL STARTING POINT

Skills in Demand (subclass 482)

A temporary skilled visa sponsored by your employer, often with a pathway to permanent residence over time.

TOWARDS PERMANENCE

Employer Nomination Scheme (subclass 186)

An employer-nominated permanent route, sometimes from the outset and sometimes after a period on a 482.

POINTS-TESTED

Skilled visas (189, 190, 491)

Independent, state-nominated and regional routes, each needing a skills assessment for your occupation.

FOR YOUR FAMILY

Partners and children

Usually included on your application. Partners generally have work rights, and children can go to school.

Questions worth asking early

- ☐ Which visa will the employer sponsor, and which occupation is it under?
- ☐ Is a permanent pathway open from this role, and when?
- ☐ What work rights will my partner have on the visa we are granted?
- ☐ Does the location count as regional for migration, and what does that change?
- ☐ What does my visa mean for Medicare, school fees and childcare in that state?

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Good to know

Perth, Adelaide, Canberra, Hobart and Darwin all count as regional for skilled migration, which surprises many people and can widen your options. We are recruiters, not registered migration agents: the Department of Home Affairs owns every rule, and we work alongside registered agents for formal advice. Start medicals and police certificates early; overseas certificates are the most common cause of delay.



Parliament House, Canberra, where migration settings are made.



Busselton, in Western Australia's South West.



Barossa Valley vineyards, about an hour from Adelaide.



Esperance, on Western Australia's south coast.



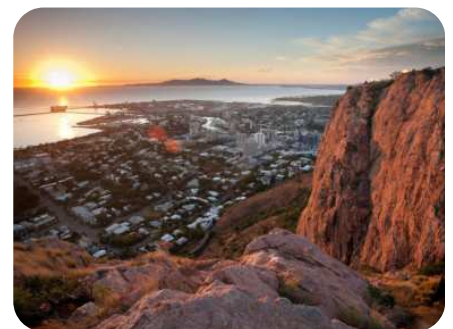
Wineglass Bay, Freycinet National Park, Tasmania.



The Kuranda Scenic Railway, in the rainforest above Cairns.



Quokkas on Rottnest Island, a ferry ride from Perth.



Townsville at sunrise, North Queensland.

How pay works in Australian healthcare

Australia has no single national pay scale. A national award sets the legal minimum, and most public-sector clinicians are paid under their state's enterprise agreement, which sits above it.

Modern awards are the national safety net, one per profession group, published by the Fair Work Ombudsman and reviewed every July. Allied health and medical imaging professionals sit under the Health Professionals and Support Services Award; nurses and midwives have their own award; doctors' pay is set by agreements and contracts.

Enterprise agreements are negotiated in each state and territory between the public health service and the relevant union. They set the pay scale, hours, leave and progression for public roles, which is why the same job can pay differently across a state line. In the private sector, employers must meet the award but are free to build their own packages above it.

Within each scale you sit on a level and a pay point, decided by your qualifications, experience (overseas years generally count) and responsibility, and you usually move up a point with each year of service. We deliberately do not publish salary figures; we confirm the right instrument and your placement for every role we discuss.



Ask for your level and pay point in writing. How your overseas experience is credited is the single largest variable in what you are actually paid.



Australian dollars. Pay is set by published awards and agreements, so the number is easy to check before you sign.

Beyond the base salary

- ✓ **Superannuation:** your employer pays 12% of ordinary earnings into a retirement fund, on top of your salary. Check whether an offer is quoted as base or as a package including super.
- ✓ **Salary packaging:** many public and not-for-profit health employers let you pay some everyday expenses from your pre-tax salary, within set limits. It can lift your take-home pay noticeably, so ask what is on offer.
- ✓ Penalty rates for weekends and public holidays, plus shift loadings and overtime.
- ✓ Four weeks' annual leave as a minimum, often a fifth for shift workers, plus long service leave.
- ✓ Relocation support, CPD funding and registration costs in many roles recruiting internationally.

	AUSTRALIA	NEW ZEALAND	UNITED KINGDOM
How pay is set	National award floor, then state enterprise agreements	National collective agreements	National pay bands
One national scale?	No: minimums are national, actual pay is by state	Yes	Broadly yes

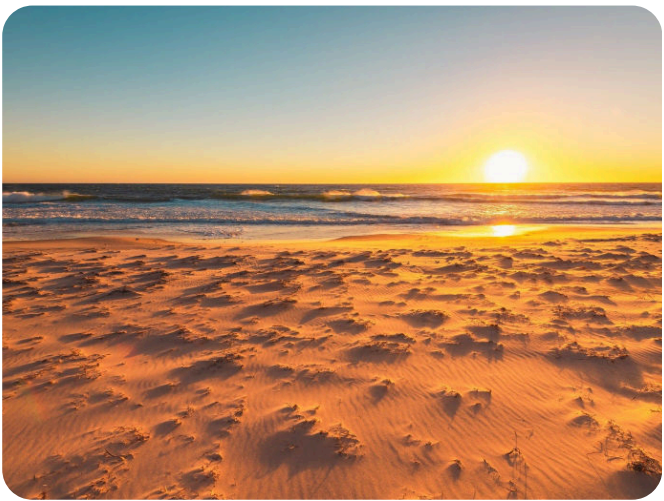
	AUSTRALIA	NEW ZEALAND	UNITED KINGDOM
On top of base	Penalties, loadings, 12% super, salary packaging	Penal rates, allowances, KiwiSaver	Unsocial-hours pay, NHS pension
Tax admin	PAYG; Medicare levy; no National Insurance	Simple PAYE; small ACC levy	PAYE plus National Insurance



A weekend paddle on Sydney Harbour: part of what the package buys.



Perth at blue hour.



Sunset on Adelaide’s southern beaches.

What it costs to live here

Australia is not a cheap country, and pay is fair. Where you live does more to your money than your payslip does, because housing costs and state pay both change when you move.

Housing is the cost that surprises newcomers most, and it varies enormously. Sydney is the most expensive city in the country to rent or buy in, with Melbourne next; Brisbane, Perth, Adelaide, Canberra, Hobart and Darwin each offer a different balance, and a regional city can stretch the same salary much further than a capital.

For most households rent is the largest single line, often taking a quarter to a third of take-home pay in the big cities and noticeably less in many regional centres. Groceries, fuel and utilities sit close to UK levels; eating out and anything imported can be dearer, while the things people actually do at the weekend, beaches, parks and bushwalks, are free.

CAPITAL	HOUSING, BROADLY	IT SUITS YOU BEST IF...
Sydney	The most expensive in the country	You want the biggest health system and the harbour lifestyle, and will choose your suburb carefully.
Melbourne	High, with more choice further out	You love a city of culture, food and trams.
Brisbane	Good value for a big city	You want tertiary work and a family home within reach, with a warm winter.
Perth	Moderate, and rising	You want the best beaches and sunshine of any capital.
Adelaide	Among the more affordable capitals	You want an easy commute, wine country close by and a calmer pace.
Canberra	Rents on the higher side; incomes too	You want a planned, leafy city with very short commutes.
Hobart	Small market, can be competitive	You want mountains, harbour and four seasons in a small city.
Darwin	Generally more affordable to rent	You want tropical life, a close community and adventure on the doorstep.

WHAT TO BUDGET FOR

Housing in the big cities

The line to model first, with real listings for the suburbs you like.

Health extras

Adult dental, optical and ambulance cover in some states, plus private cover if your visa requires it.

School and childcare

Fees for some temporary visa holders depending on the state, and childcare before school age.

Flights home

A real annual line for most families. Plan one trip every year or two, deliberately.

WHAT GOES FURTHER

Regional living

Lower housing costs, shorter commutes and often regional incentives.

Superannuation

Twelve per cent on top of salary, real money that a simple salary comparison misses.

Time

Short commutes in most cities give hours back to the week.

The outdoors

Beaches, national parks and free barbecues in the park are part of everyday life.



A classic Queenslander, raised up with a wide veranda for the warm climate.



Fresh produce at Adelaide's Central Market.



The flat white: a small daily luxury most Australians would not give up.

BUDGET FOR YOUR FIRST WEEKS

- ✓ Bond and rent in advance, a car, furniture and school uniforms often land together in the first month.
- ✓ Give your employer your tax file number promptly so you are taxed at the right rate from the start.
- ✓ Allow for the time between arriving and your first full pay; planning for it makes the first months far easier.



SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

What I tell people about Australia

Australia rewards people who understand that it is one registration system and eight employment systems. Registration opens the whole country; pay, conditions, school fees and the feel of the work change at every state line. So read the systems once, then choose your state, in that order.

What I love seeing is the moment a family stops picturing the holiday and starts picturing the ordinary days: the school run, the early swim, the barbecue with new friends on a Sunday. Ask yourself whether that life feels like yours. If it does, the rest is just steps, and you will not be taking them alone.

Sophie Careem

Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing



The ordinary weekend: on the water, outdoors, together.



Tasmania's east coast.

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures

Australia is home to the world's oldest continuous living cultures, cared for by Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples for more than 60,000 years. In healthcare, respect for those cultures is part of everyday good practice, and nobody expects you to arrive an expert.

There is no single Aboriginal culture. Hundreds of distinct nations, each with its own language, law and Country, cover the continent, and Torres Strait Islander peoples have their own cultures across the islands between Cape York and Papua New Guinea. Country means more than land: it is family, identity, responsibility and wellbeing, and many patients understand health in exactly those connected terms.

Colonisation and its continuing effects are part of the clinical picture, and health outcomes remain unequal. Closing the Gap, the national agreement to close those gaps in life expectancy, health and wellbeing, shapes service plans and funding, and you will hear the term often. It is meaningful work to be part of.

60,000+

years of continuous culture

250+

First Nations languages at the time of colonisation

~4%

of Australians identify as Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander
2021 Census

ANYONE CAN GIVE ONE

Acknowledgement of Country

A short statement of respect to the Traditional Custodians, often opening meetings, education sessions and events. Take it as clinical business, not ceremony.

GIVEN BY TRADITIONAL OWNERS

Welcome to Country

A ceremony offered by an Elder or representative of the local people, welcoming visitors onto their Country.

CARE BY COMMUNITY, FOR COMMUNITY

Community-controlled health services

Aboriginal Community Controlled Health Organisations deliver care designed and governed by the people they serve. You may refer to them, work beside them, or be employed by one.

COLLEAGUES TO LEARN FROM

Aboriginal Health Workers and Practitioners

Trusted members of many teams, bridging culture and care. Ask for their guidance; it is freely given.

What culturally safe practice looks like

- ☐ Learn whose Country your service stands on, and how to say the name.
- ☐ Take the cultural induction seriously; it is written into the codes of conduct you practise under.
- ☐ Ask who should be part of the conversation; family often should be.
- ☐ Explain before you touch, and check understanding gently.
- ☐ Notice when someone has gone quiet; silence is not agreement.
- ☐ Accept correction warmly. Nobody expects fluency on arrival, and people notice effort.



Rock art in Kakadu, in the Northern Territory: some of the oldest art on earth.



Ikara-Flinders Ranges in South Australia, Country of the Adnyamathanha people.



A red kangaroo on the open plains.



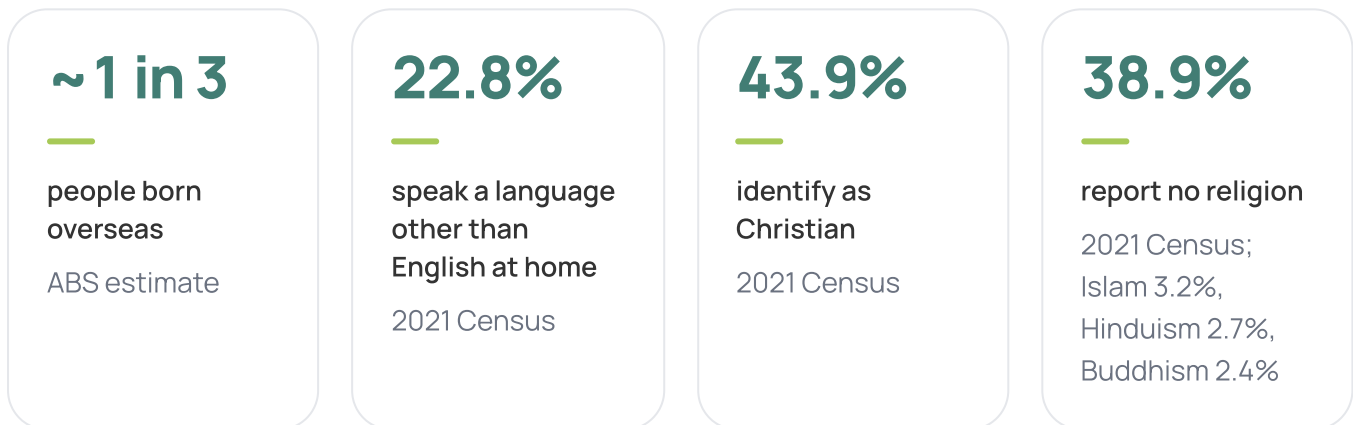
Country in Queensland at sunset.

Bringing your culture and faith with you

Australia is one of the most multicultural countries in the world. Whatever your faith, food or festivals, a community has very likely got there before you, especially in the capital cities.

Around one in three people living in Australia was born overseas, and almost half have at least one parent who was. After England, the largest groups were born in India, China, New Zealand and the Philippines, with big, settled South African, Vietnamese, Irish, Sri Lankan and Malaysian communities, and Pacific and Middle Eastern families in every capital.

The capitals are where that diversity is richest: in many suburbs most residents were born overseas and you will hear dozens of languages on the way to work. Large regional cities are mixed and growing more so, often around the hospitals and universities that draw people from everywhere. Smaller country towns are quieter and less diverse, and many newcomers love their close-knit pace; if your faith or culture is central to your life, it is worth choosing your town with that in mind, and we are always glad to help.



Freedom of religion is protected, and so is freedom from discrimination because of your beliefs. Faith is mostly a private matter at work, yet churches, mosques, temples and gurdwaras sit comfortably in ordinary suburbs, and faith communities are often the fastest route to friendship and practical help when you arrive.

Christian churches of every tradition, Catholic, Anglican, Uniting, Pentecostal and Orthodox, are found in every city and most towns, many with services in other languages, including Syro-Malabar and Malayalam-speaking Catholic communities in the larger cities. Long-established Muslim communities run mosques and Islamic centres in all the capitals. Hindu temples and gurdwaras are well established and growing, Buddhist temples and meditation centres reflect the country's Asian communities, and Jewish communities are concentrated in Sydney and Melbourne.



Kirtan at a Melbourne gurdwara.



The mosque in Mareeba, a small town on Queensland's Atherton Tablelands.

CATHOLIC.ORG.AU · ANGLICAN.ORG.AU ·
UNITING.CHURCH

Christian

National churches with parishes nationwide. Ask your local Catholic diocese about Syro-Malabar and language Masses.

[AUSTRALIAN NATIONAL IMAMS COUNCIL ·
ANIC.ORG.AU](http://AUSTRALIAN NATIONAL IMAMS COUNCIL · ANIC.ORG.AU)

Muslim

A national voice for imams and Muslim communities, and a good route to local mosques and halal certification.

[HINDU COUNCIL OF AUSTRALIA ·
HINDUCOUNCIL.COM.AU](http://HINDU COUNCIL OF AUSTRALIA · HINDUCOUNCIL.COM.AU)

Hindu

The peak body linking temples and cultural associations in every state.

[EXECUTIVE COUNCIL OF AUSTRALIAN
JEWRY · ECAJ.ORG.AU](http://EXECUTIVE COUNCIL OF AUSTRALIAN JEWRY · ECAJ.ORG.AU)

Jewish

The national roof body for Jewish communities, and the best route to congregations and kosher suppliers.

[LOCAL GURDWARA AND TEMPLE
COMMITTEES](http://LOCAL GURDWARA AND TEMPLE COMMITTEES)

Sikh and Buddhist

Gurdwaras serve every capital and a number of regional centres, with langar and a practical welcome; Buddhist temples span every tradition.

FECCA.ORG.AU

Multicultural councils

The Federation of Ethnic Communities' Councils links each state's ethnic communities council, a good first call for local groups.

The calendar is generous and public. Diwali, Eid, Lunar New Year, Holi and Vaisakhi are celebrated openly, often as city-wide events. NAIDOC Week each July celebrates Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures, and Anzac Day in April is a moving national day of remembrance. Christmas falls in high summer, so expect a barbecue, the beach and seafood rather than snow.

Food is one of the joys of the move. Supermarkets carry growing world-food aisles, and the cities have large Indian, Asian, Middle Eastern, African and European grocers. Halal is easy to find in the cities; kosher is concentrated in Sydney and Melbourne. Australians love a good coffee, a weekend brunch and a shared table, and an invitation to “bring a plate” simply means bring a dish to share.



The tastes of home are rarely far away in the cities.



Melbourne's Chinatown, one of the oldest in the western world.



Darwin's Mindil Beach Sunset Market in the dry season.

How friendships form

- ✓ **Through the children:** school gates, weekend sport and Nippers at the local surf club are where families meet fastest.
- ✓ **Through work:** colleagues are often your first community, and many have made the same move.
- ✓ **Through one regular thing:** a class, a choir, a team or a place of worship gives your week the same faces each time.
- ✓ **Through sport:** cricket in summer; Australian rules football in Victoria, South Australia, Western Australia and Tasmania; rugby league in New South Wales and Queensland; netball, soccer and a weekly parkrun almost everywhere.
- ✓ **Around the barbecue:** invitations are casual, so say yes, and return them.

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Keep hold of your own culture and let Australia welcome you at the same time. You don't have to choose.

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Finding your community

Each city guide includes a local directory of places of worship, cultural associations and specialist grocers. Start there once you know where you are heading, and tell us about your faith and family: we are always glad to make an introduction before you land.



Holi in Australia: festivals travel with the people who keep them.



The beach is where many friendships begin.



Asian food is part of everyday Australian eating.



Weekend brunch: a national pastime.



Learning to surf starts young.



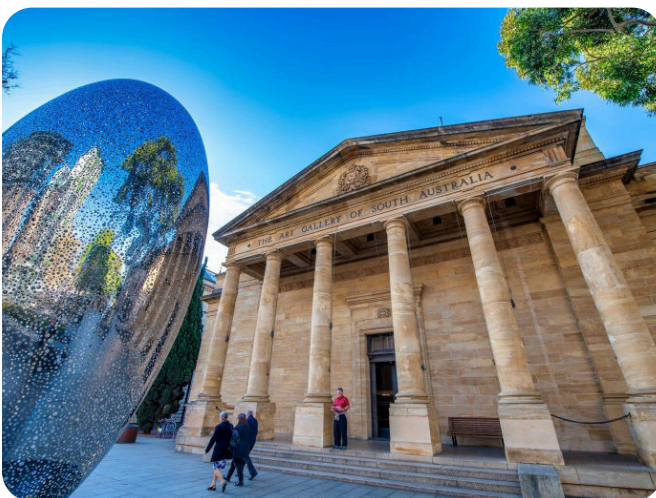
Weekends on the water.



The Fleurieu Peninsula, south of Adelaide.



Fremantle, Perth's port city, where café culture spills onto the street.



The Art Gallery of South Australia, Adelaide.



Fresh oysters, a South Australian favourite.

Moving as a family

Partners are usually included on your visa and generally able to work, children can come with you and go to school, and many roles offer a pathway to permanent residence.

Your partner’s right to work comes from your visa rather than a job offer of their own, so check the conditions before you accept. If they are a clinician too, run both registrations from the start. Many families plan the first months on one income and are pleasantly surprised.

Schools are run by each state and territory, following a common Australian Curriculum. Government schools sit alongside a large Catholic sector, often more affordable than families expect, and a wide range of independent schools. Most government schools have a catchment zone, so the school and the home are one decision: research schools first, then rentals. The school year runs from late January or early February to mid-December, in four terms.



Senior school: clear pathways to university and vocational training



Early learning is a gentle on-ramp before school starts at around five.

STATE OR TERRITORY	GOVERNMENT SCHOOL FEES FOR TEMPORARY VISA HOLDERS	WORTH KNOWING
Victoria	Generally none	Children usually enrol as local students; confirm your subclass.
Queensland	Generally none	A fee waiver for 482 dependants; a small application fee may apply.
Northern Territory	None	No tuition fees for 482 dependants.
Tasmania	No tuition	A modest school levy applies instead.

STATE OR TERRITORY	GOVERNMENT SCHOOL FEES FOR TEMPORARY VISA HOLDERS	WORTH KNOWING
New South Wales	Fees apply in Greater Sydney	Waived in regional NSW; some skills-list occupations are exempt.
South Australia	Fees apply	Income-tested, with sibling discounts and some country schools exempt.
Western Australia	Fees apply	Charged per family rather than per child for certain skilled visas.
Australian Capital Territory	Fees apply	Exempt where your occupation is on the skills list.



Check your own position

Rules turn on your exact visa subclass, occupation and sometimes income, and they are revised each year. Confirm the current position with the state or territory education department for the year you move. Permanent residents and citizens attend government schools on the same basis as local families. Many of the healthcare occupations we place are exempt.

UNDER FIVE

Long day care and family day care

Centres cover the full working day; family day care is a smaller setting in an educator's home. Join waiting lists from overseas as soon as you have a suburb in mind.

UP TO 90% OF FEES

The Child Care Subsidy

Paid directly to your provider and scaled by family income, at up to 90%. Second and younger children aged five or under can attract a higher rate.

CHECK BEFORE BUDGETING

Residency matters

Permanent residents and citizens are generally eligible; many temporary visa families, including most on a 482, are not, so plan on full fees until you have checked.



An ordinary after-school playground in Western Australia.



A calm creek mouth an easy drive from Brisbane: the kind of water you take small children to.



After the bell.



Outdoor play is at the heart of early learning.



Plenty of children are surfing before they are ten



Creative, play-based learning in the early years.



Meeting the locals: koalas in Queensland.

Choosing where in Australia to live

Registration opens the whole country; pay, schools, weather and daily life change at every state line. Our guides cover the eight capital cities and six regional cities, so you can picture the move before you make it.

Each guide covers the same ground for one place: the work, the suburbs, the commute, the cost of living, the weekends and the schools. Start with the capitals, then look at the regional cities, which are often the smartest move of all.



An honest word about the big cities

Competition for healthcare roles is very high in the metro cities of Sydney, Melbourne, Brisbane, Perth and Adelaide, and securing a role and sponsorship there is considerably more challenging than in regional Australia. We are not saying it's impossible, but we want to be honest with you. Keeping a regional city on your shortlist gives you the best chance, and many clinicians move to a capital later with Australian experience behind them.

NEW SOUTH WALES · HARBOUR CITY

Sydney

The largest health system in the country, world-famous beaches and a harbour at the heart of everything.

VICTORIA · CULTURE CAPITAL

Melbourne

A deep tertiary and research bench, the world's largest tram network, and food, sport and the arts on every corner.

QUEENSLAND · SUBTROPICAL

Brisbane

Tertiary work and a family home within easy reach, with a winter you look forward to.

AUSTRALIAN CAPITAL TERRITORY · PLANNED AND LEAFY

Canberra

Short commutes, a lake at the centre of the plan, and high incomes in a calm, green city.

TASMANIA · HARBOUR AND MOUNTAIN

Hobart

A mountain over the city, a working harbour and a health system small enough to know your name.

WESTERN AUSTRALIA · SUNSHINE

Perth

The best beaches and weather of any capital, newer hospitals and a relaxed outdoor life.

SOUTH AUSTRALIA · EASY-GOING

Adelaide

Tertiary work twenty minutes from home, wine country under an hour away, and festivals all year.

NORTHERN TERRITORY · TROPICAL

Darwin

Australia's gateway to Asia, with a close community, wide scope and adventure on the doorstep.

Four questions to build a shortlist

- ☐ What size of department do you want to work in?
- ☐ Which climate will you still love in your third summer and your third winter?
- ☐ What does your partner need from the place, and what do your children?
- ☐ How do school fees, housing and state pay combine for your household?

QUEENSLAND · REGIONAL CITY

Gold Coast

Fifty-seven kilometres of surf, a rainforest hinterland and a growing tertiary teaching hospital, an hour from Brisbane.

NEW SOUTH WALES · REGIONAL CITY

Newcastle

A harbour city rebuilt around its surf beaches, with a major referral hospital, wine country nearby and Sydney two hours south.

VICTORIA · REGIONAL CITY

Geelong

A bayside city on Corio Bay, with the Surf Coast and the Great Ocean Road at its back door and Melbourne an hour away.

QUEENSLAND · REGIONAL CITY

Bundaberg

A warm river city on the Coral Coast, gateway to the southern Great Barrier Reef, where clinicians are warmly welcomed and much needed.

WESTERN AUSTRALIA · REGIONAL CITY

Mandurah

A waterside city on the Peel estuary, with dolphins in the canals and Perth under an hour away by train.

WESTERN AUSTRALIA · REGIONAL CITY

Bunbury

The South West's largest city and referral centre, with beaches, forests and wineries close by, two hours south of Perth.



Gold Coast: surf at the city's doorstep.



Newcastle: the Ocean Baths and Newcastle Beach.



Geelong: the Corio Bay waterfront.



Bundaberg: the coast at Bargara.



Mandurah: pelicans on the shore.



Bunbury: the Marlston waterfront.



Melbourne: Flinders Street Station.



Brisbane: the river and the city.



Canberra: the National Arboretum.



Hobart: the docks below kunanyi / Mount Wellington.



Adelaide: the River Torrens at dusk.



Darwin: the waterfront.

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Why look regional

Regional cities are where demand for clinicians is strongest. Scope is broad, housing goes further, commutes are short, and regional visa pathways and incentives often apply. We are always glad to talk through places you may not have heard of yet.



Sydney: Lavender Bay and the Harbour Bridge.



Townsville, one of Queensland's big regional cities.



Sunrise on the Gold Coast.



Waterside living in Mandurah.



Geelong's waterfront at dusk.

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Picture the ordinary Tuesday, not the postcard. If it feels like yours, Australia is ready when you are.

Numbers and websites to keep handy

The official sources worth bookmarking before you go: health, schools, visas, tax, renting and settling in.

000 / 112 / 13 11 14 / 13 11 26 / 13 11 436

Emergency services

Police, fire and ambulance, any time
000

Emergency from a mobile

Also connects to emergency services from any mobile phone
112

healthdirect

Free 24/7 health advice from a registered nurse
1800 022 222 [healthdirect.gov.au](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au)

Lifeline

24/7 crisis support and suicide prevention, by phone, text or chat
13 11 14 [lifeline.org.au](https://www.lifeline.org.au)

Poisons Information Centre

24/7 advice if someone may have been poisoned
13 11 26

Pregnancy, Birth and Baby

Free support for parents from pregnancy to preschool
1800 882 436 [pregnancybirthbaby.org.au](https://www.pregnancybirthbaby.org.au)

132 011 / 13 13 94 / 13 11 436 / 13 11 26 / 13 11 14

Medicare · Services Australia

Enrolment, cards, claims and reciprocal health care agreements
132 011 [servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare](https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare)

healthdirect service finder

Find a GP, pharmacy, urgent care or hospital near you
[healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services)

privatehealth.gov.au

Compare private health cover independently; run by the Commonwealth Ombudsman
[privatehealth.gov.au](https://www.privatehealth.gov.au)

Private health insurance complaints

The Commonwealth Ombudsman's free complaints service
1300 737 299 [ombudsman.gov.au](https://www.ombudsman.gov.au)

1300 419 495 / 13 11 436 / 13 11 26 / 13 11 14

Department of Home Affairs

Visas, skilled occupation lists and processing times
[immi.homeaffairs.gov.au](https://www.immi.homeaffairs.gov.au)

ImmiAccount

Lodge and track your visa application online
online.immi.gov.au

Register of migration agents (OMARA)

Check an agent is registered before you pay
[mara.gov.au](https://www.mara.gov.au)

Ahpra

National registration and the National Boards
1300 419 495 [ahpra.gov.au](https://www.ahpra.gov.au)

Fair Work Ombudsman

Awards, pay rates and your rights at work
13 13 94 [fairwork.gov.au](https://www.fairwork.gov.au)

1300 419 495 / 13 11 436 / 13 11 26 / 13 11 14

NSW school finder

Government schools and catchments in New South Wales
[education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder](https://www.education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder)

Find my school (Victoria)

School zones for any Victorian address
findmyschool.vic.gov.au

Find a school (Queensland)

State schools and catchment areas
qld.gov.au/education/schools/find

Find a public school (WA)

Western Australian public schools and local-intake areas
wa.gov.au/service/education-and-training/school-education/find-public-school

School zones (South Australia)

Zone maps for government schools
education.sa.gov.au/parents-and-families/enrol-school-or-preschool/zones-catchments-and-capacity-management/maps-school-zones-enrolment-year

Find your local school (Tasmania)

Intake areas for Tasmanian government schools
decyp.tas.gov.au/learning/find-your-local-school

Priority enrolment areas (ACT)

Find a Canberra public school for your address
act.gov.au/education-and-training/find-a-school-and-enrol

Choose a school (NT)

Urban and remote schools in the Northern Territory
nt.gov.au/learning/primary-and-secondary-students/choose-a-school

Starting Blocks

Compare childcare services and quality ratings near you
startingblocks.gov.au

Child Care Subsidy

Eligibility, rates and how to apply
servicesaustralia.gov.au/child-care-subsidy

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Australian Taxation Office

Apply for your tax file number (TFN), tax and super
[13 28 61 ato.gov.au](http://132861ato.gov.au)

Moneysmart

Free, independent budgeting, super and banking tools
moneysmart.gov.au

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TIS National

Free interpreting by phone, 24/7, in 150+ languages
[131 450 tisnational.gov.au](http://131450tisnational.gov.au)

Settle in Australia

Home Affairs' settlement topics and services for new arrivals
immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/settling-in-australia

MyAus app

Government app to help newcomers find services, in many languages
myausapp.com

Overseas drivers (Austroads)

How overseas licences are recognised, with links to each state's licensing authority
austroads.gov.au/drivers-and-vehicles/overseas-drivers/country-recognition



Always check the source

Rules, fees and services change. Treat these as starting points and confirm details with the organisation. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not registered migration agents.

Six steps, and someone beside you for each one

Moving country is a sequence of decisions. We take them with you in order, so you are never solving step five before step two is done.



STEP 1

Discovery call

A relaxed conversation about your profession, your family and what you want from a move. No forms, no pressure.



STEP 2

Eligibility & registration

We map your route to Ahpra registration and help you gather the evidence the regulator will ask for.



STEP 3

Opportunities & interviews

Roles matched to where you want to live and how you like to work, with honest briefings before every interview.



STEP 4

Offer & decision support

We help you read the offer properly: pay step, relocation support, roster and what the team is really like.



STEP 5

Visa & relocation guidance

Practical guidance on visas, shipping, pets, schools and the first weeks, so nothing arrives as a surprise.



STEP 6

Settling in

We stay in touch after you land, from your first week on the ward to your first winter.



— READY TO EXPLORE OPPORTUNITIES?

Picture yourself in Australia. Then let's make it real.

Tell us what you do and where you would like to live. We will come back with roles that fit, a clear view of the registration route, and time to answer every question.



Ethicare Resourcing

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